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WEB PAGE EDITOR: PETER COONEY 987-2441

Good grammar a click away

Fuzzy on the affect/effect distinction? This site will set you straight

DAVID COLKER
Los Angeles Times

LOS ANGELES – Remember those teachers who red-penciled every sample of your writing to point out errors in grammar, usage and spelling?

Now they're on the Web.

Several sites have sprung up to wage war on split infinitives, misspellings, improper punctuation, double negatives, mismatched pronouns, redundancies and bad word choices in English.

One is the online version of *The Gazette* Style (www.montrealgazette.com/STYLE/), the guide used by reporters and editors at *The Gazette*.

The proprietors of some usage sites have gone so far as to employ search engines to hunt down dreaded errors and compile statistics to prove how widespread they have become. These are the kind of people who tend to get the seat next to me on a cross-country flight. Most of their sites come in three basic flavours – nagging, disparaging or superior.

But there is a major exception – the plainly named but introspective and good-humoured Common Errors in English site created by Paul Brians of Washington State University.

Actually, Brians has created several interesting sites concerning literature and writing. You can get to them from his home page (www.wsu.edu:~brians).

In his introduction to Common Errors, he admits that his degree is in comparative literature, not composition or linguistics, so he's not a certified expert. But as someone who simply admires good writing, he created this site to help students "avoid low grades, lost employment opportunities, lost business and titters of amusement at the way you write or speak."

This is a practical site that recognizes the best way to use language effectively is to know its rules.

"You have a right to express yourself in any manner you please," Brians writes, "but if you wish to communicate effectively, you should use nonstandard English only when you intend to, rather than falling into it because you don't know any better."

The site then goes on to examine dozens of examples of common errors. Near the top of the alphabetical list is the distinction between affect and effect. I admit I've never quite been able to master this.

Brians doesn't apologize for the confusion. "Hey, nobody ever said English was logical," he writes. "Just memorize it and get on with your life."

In a similar manner, he goes on to examine the differences between imply and infer, adapt and adopt and prophecy and prophesy.

In his section on further and further, he writes that some authorities insist farther should refer only to physical distance, and further should be used only when referring to time or degree. Brians doesn't seem too concerned about this one, but he warns it can make some people "really testy."

Brians takes on words that are commonly misused, pointing out that "historic" should always refer to something that is of interest to historians or simply famous in history. All too often, the term is used to describe something that is simply old.

Brians mentions common redundancies, such as references to the "HIV virus."

And here's one that was a real surprise to me. The "real" in medieval means ages. So if we talk about the "medieval ages," we're really saying "Middle Ages ages."

Perhaps my favourite section of this site is Non-Errors, in which Brians takes on "those usages people keep telling you are wrong, but which are actually standard in English."

Split infinitives need no longer be strictly avoided, he writes. For example, the phrase at the beginning of Star Trek that describes the ship's mission as one "to boldly go where no man has gone before" (or, in the Next Generation version of the show, "to boldly go where no one has gone before") should technically begin, "to go boldly." But Brians says the phrase used on the show is offensive only to the hypercritical.

As for ending a sentence with a preposition, Brians mentions Winston Churchill's wry comment: "From now on, ending a sentence with a preposition is something up with which I will not put."

Brians also takes on those who insist that the word "hopefully" can only mean "in a hopeful fashion" (hoping, in his words, "more hopefulness than realism").

I don't agree with everything Brians says. He maintains that the word "between" can be used to refer to more than two objects.

Unlike most people on the Web who lord over correct-usage sites, Brians recognizes that language evolves. The ebbs and flows in usage can sometimes set one's teeth on edge, but they can also make language a dynamic, living entity.

Those who maintain that language must remain static should be forced to read Chaucer from the original texts.

Netscape: Common Errors in English

Back | Forward | Home | Reload | Images | Open | Print | Find | Stop

location: http://www.wsu.edu/~brians/errors/index.html

Common Errors in English

What is an error in English?
The concept of language errors is a fuzzy one. I'll leave to linguists the technical definitions. Here we're concerned only with deviations from the standard use of English as judged by sophisticated users such as professional writers, editors, teachers, and literate executives and personnel officers. The sum of this site is to help you avoid low grades, lost employment opportunities, lost business, and titters of amusement at the way you write or speak.

But isn't one person's mistake another's standard usage?
Often enough, but if your standard usage causes other people to consider you stupid or ignorant, you may want to consider changing it. You have the right to express yourself in any manner you please, but if you wish to communicate effectively you should use nonstandard English only when you intend to rather than falling into it because you don't know any better.

Site is a simple, practical source for guidance on good English.

Sites of interest on blacks

Washington Post

WASHINGTON – With Black History Month beginning, it seems appropriate to look at Web sites of particular interest to the black community.

One place to start is Everything Black (www.everythingblack.com), a sort of mega mall home page. It displays 12 broad categories – from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel – that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including black community news outlets.

There are numerous specialized sites, too. Mosaicbooks.com/The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon.com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature.

Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a fledgling database/search engine that aspires to be "your Internet resource of black history information."

Black Urban Professionals Online (www.bupjie.com) provides parenting tips, a resume databank, guidance on personal finance and professional and social calendars.

For children, Sheldon Jewette, owner of Computers 101, a Washington computer training centre, recommends the Afro-American Kids' Zone (www.afroam.org/children/children.html). It offers fables, games, puzzles and brain teasers.

Encyclopedia makes online searching fun

Washington Post

WASHINGTON – One of the fun things about an encyclopedia is all the stuff you learn while you're flipping through the pages trying to find what you're actually looking for.

Encyclopedia.com (www.encyclopedia.com), then, is a cure for those of us with wandering eyes and short attention spans. By providing direct connections to related articles, it turns detours into relevant data.

For instance, the entry for Louis Pasteur features links to "Bacteria," "Pasteurization," "Anthrax" and "Rabies." Click on "Related Internet Sites" to put out an APB to every major search engine, from AltaVista to Yahoo, for (potentially) relevant Web pages on your subject.

Based on the Concise Columbia Electronic Encyclopedia, third edition – the same one Microsoft sells with its Bookshelf reference CD-ROM – this is a good one-stop source for both quick fact-checking and preliminary research.

The entries in this online encyclopedia, the first one to be offered free on the Web, are generally short (which can be a virtue to time-starved researchers), but the many links under each topic can help you focus on just what aspect of a subject you're seeking information on.

Coping with depression: help is out there

THE GOOD STUFF
DAVID ZGODZINSKI

February and depression can be practically synonymous. With the first few weeks of this year seemingly lasting a month each, the winter of '98 is going to feel especially long. Cabin fever has more severe symptoms when it's cold and dark inside as well as outside.

All of us are getting a bit edgy and irritable, and there may be some real emotional problems that you or someone close you need to cope with. If so, shut your eyes, take a few deep breaths and head out to the Web. You can find a lot of help for the February blahs and other psychological conditions. There are Web sites with information, others where you can ask questions, support groups and more.

Mental Health Net (www.cmhc.com) wants to become the Home Depot of trauma, and is doing a pretty good job as one of the Web's major resources for psychology.

Mental Health Net has four major categories: disorders, treatments, professional resources and the reading room. You can click on a disorder – depression, for example – and you find several subheadings: Symptoms, Treatment and Online Resources, Organizations, and Online Support. The symptoms descriptions are concise and somewhat dry condensed versions from the American Psychiatric Association, but they give you the general idea. Check out the symptoms for depression and see if you don't have at least one or two on the long list.

Each disorder has an excellent links page where you find good descriptions of dozens of Web sites concerned with that disorder. The sites are rated individually by Mental Health Net, and separately by readers, and you can add your vote for any site. Great job.

Mental Health Net even has a psychology-jokes department. This is a good addition to any Web site that deals with difficulties of the psyche. There's no ionic like laughter. Here's one:

Question: How do you tell the difference between the staff and the inmates at a psychiatric hospital?

Answer: The patients get better and leave.

Self-Help and Psychology Magazine (www.cyberhighway.net/~shrink/) is a professional publication on the Web with great features. There are free online courses on topics such as "Lesbian, Gay and Bisexual People: Myths and Realities." There are articles on a wide range of emotional and psychological topics. There are also contests, question and answer features and more that make the site worth a visit.

If you're interested in psychoanalysis and want to understand the history of the process, you should go to the source: Sigmund Freud. A site called Sigmund Freud and the Freud Archives (http://plaza.interport.net/nypsan/freudarc.html) offers a comprehensive collection of Freud's writings and well-selected links.

Many Usenet newsgroups are devoted to psychological problems, and the format is a perfect fit – it's an instant worldwide support group. Contributors are anonymous. They can all relate to each other's problems. They give helpful information, such as what to do about the side-effects of medication.

The best place to find out about newsgroups for psychological problems is a Web site called Support Group.com (www.support-group.com). The site began as a local bulletin board in Florida discussing Graves disease. The board opened up to contacts on the Internet, and the idea blossomed.

There is online chat about all types of health problems, and art and poetry submitted by users.

But the core of the site is a directory of hundreds of diseases and health concerns. Most are physical, but a full range of emotional and psychological ailments is also included.

There is a page for each ailment. Support.com has set up an online bulletin board, and more importantly has a full set of good Web links devoted to each malady. This is also the place to find links to the newsgroups that deal with topics like depression (seven newsgroups) obsessive-compulsive disorder (two newsgroups) and others. The site is thorough.

The dangers of relying too much on a box for emotional help are obvious, whether the box be a TV, radio or computer. There are psychologists purveying advice everywhere these days. Some of it may be helpful for people with basic problems. But when February blahs degenerate into serious psychological problems, clicking through a few Web sites is not going to come up with the solution, and professionals should be consulted.

Still, professional healers and sufferers alike are using the Web to set up beacons for others who may need help. And all that can't hurt for people who are feeling a bit cold and lonely these days.

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